The Vision Quest, often highlighting it as a **profound and ancient rite of passage** that has been adapted for modern times. A core aspect of understanding the vision quest is recognizing its **three-stage process**, originally identified by anthropologist Arnold van Gennep. These stages are: **severance, threshold, and incorporation.**

Here's what the sources say about these three stages in the larger context of a Vision Quest:

- **1. Severance (Séparation)**
    - This initial phase involves **preparation to break from the former world** and leave daily life behind. It is about "letting go" of old behaviors, places, and situations that no longer serve one's potential.
    - Participants are encouraged to **clarify their intent—**what they hope to gain or understand from their quest. This process of "letting go" can be difficult but is the first step in acknowledging one's true self and gifts.
    - Preparation may include **physical and spiritual cleansing**, such as prayers and sweat lodges. Keeping a **journal** during this period is recommended to clarify understanding and identify personal issues.
    - Preparatory meetings, often in a **council** format with guides, help participants acquire survival information, discuss the meaning of their life passage, and address potential psychological challenges and personal fears.
    - Symbolically, severance is likened to **death preceding new birth**, where former limitations are torn down to establish new boundaries. This stage also involves a "day walk" in nature early in preparation to stimulate deeper thoughts about intent.
- **2. Threshold (Marge)**
    - This is the **core experience** of solitude and fasting in the wilderness. It is a deeply personal and sacred time of uncertainty and mystery, a "liminal time" between the old life and the life yet to come.
    - Participants abstain from food and often water for a period, typically **three or four days and nights.** This pushes seekers beyond their physical comfort zone and deepens their focus.
    - During this time, one faces **fears**, reflects, meditates, and "cries out for a vision". The Lakota term for this practice is *hąbléc'eyapi*, meaning "crying for a dream/vision".
    - **Dreams** and waking fantasies are considered important, potentially revealing symbols or messages that require interpretation. The natural environment itself, including animals and elements, is seen as a source of wisdom and healing, providing signs and speaking to the quester.
    - The challenges of hunger, loneliness, and exposure are crucial in helping participants push through barriers and open themselves to receiving visions or spiritual guidance. The objective is to achieve a **heightened awareness** of body, emotions, feelings, and thoughts.

- **3. Incorporation (Agrégation)**
    - This final phase is about **returning from the journey** and integrating the insights gained into one's daily life. It is often described as the **most difficult step**, as the challenge lies in "living the vision in the world for all people to see".
    - Participants return to their community or a **council setting**, where they share their stories. Guides and elders help to "mirror" or reflect the meaning of these stories and visions, empowering the individual to accept and apply their newfound understanding.
    - The aim is to bring back the "boon" or "gift" received during the quest, which is meant to be shared for the benefit of the community or "the people".
    - A common post-quest experience is a "**predictable depression**," which is viewed as a necessary part of growth as the individual confronts the gap between their transformative experience and the ordinary world. This phase focuses on how the experience and insights can be applied towards positive change and profound growth.

In the Larger Context of Vision Quest:

- **Purpose and Transformation:** The three stages are integral to the core purpose of a vision quest, which is to find **guidance, strength, and purpose in life** through self-discovery, spiritual insight, and personal transformation. The experience aims to renew and revitalize the individual human spirit, providing deeper fulfillment and meaning.
- **Ancient Tradition and Modern Adaptation:** While rooted in millennia-old practices of traditional cultures worldwide, particularly Native American cultures, modern vision quests like those offered by the School of Lost Borders are "pan-cultural, eclectic, and geared to the modern experience". They simulate these ancient activities, addressing a perceived loss of vision, beliefs, and values in contemporary society and a disconnection from nature.
- **The Role of Nature and Solitude:** Across all three stages, especially the threshold, the **wilderness, naturalness, and solitude** are emphasized as essential for deep reflection, insight, and connection to self, nature, and a larger spiritual reality. This allows individuals to strip away distractions and push beyond comfort zones.
- **Community and Guides:** Although the threshold is a solo experience, the broader vision quest process is often supported by **guides ("midwives" or "elders")** and a community. Guides facilitate preparation, ensure safety during solo time, and assist with the crucial integration of insights. Traditionally, the community played a significant role in welcoming the quester back and recognizing their new role, as the vision was understood to benefit the collective.
- **"Vision" as a Broad Concept:** The "vision" sought is not necessarily a grand, showy awakening, but rather the **faculty or state of being able to see**, the ability to think about or plan the future with imagination or wisdom. It can be wisdom, insight, the ability to dream, creative energy, one's life work, or a marrow-deep feeling of self-recognition

and potential. The ultimate goal is to "perform their vision on earth for the people to see" and to live one's myth.

The sources show that these three stages provide a **structured framework** for a deeply personal and transformative journey, designed to help individuals reconnect with themselves, nature, and a larger spiritual reality, and to bring their newfound insights into practical action in their daily lives.